At 6.30 p.m. on 15 November, Major Malik, commanding Delta Company on the eastern bank, reported a number of Chinese with torches moving from the north towards Ashi Hill. This message was communicated to all the troops deployed on the west bank. Two hours later, Patrol Base was attacked but the Sikhs were alert and fought off the assault.

Chinese artillery began to pound Patrol Base with a vengeance. The post took a hammering and at 11.30 p.m., the Chinese launched yet another attack. Casualties were mounting and 4 Sikh's Alpha Company commander Major Samvatsar was severely wounded. Yet the men held on grimly. Bleeding profusely, Samvatsar asked for permission to fall back on Maha Plateau. Permission was granted, but the men were not willing to fall back without the company commander and the other wounded.

The Chinese were unrelenting, but the Sikhs refused to yield. Two men in the meantime had got detached from the post. They reported at Battalion HQ and described the situation at Patrol Base. Lieutenant Colonel Behl immediately collected every man he could spare and put them under the command of the unit quartermaster, Captain Inder Jit Kumar, and rushed them to Patrol Base.

Kumar now had a tricky problem. The only hope he had of evacuating Samvatsar from Patrol Base depended on some men volunteering to cover the withdrawal. Three jawans—Lance Naik Santok Singh, Sepoy Tehar Singh and Mela Singh—opted to stay back. It was a suicidal task, but it gave Kumar's party the window it needed to try and get away. Hardly had they left Patrol Base, than a shell landed on Samvatsar, killing him instantly. Kumar was knocked down and captured by the Chinese while the company JCO was also killed. The battered remnants of Alpha Company made it to Maha Plateau. Major Samvatsar, one JCO and twenty jawans were killed while two JCOs and forty jawans were wounded. (Among the dead were four sportsmen who had represented India at the Olympics.)

The Chinese, in a shocking display of brutality, vented their anger on the dead and wounded. After the ceasefire, when an Indian recovery party went to Patrol Base, they found corpses whose hands and feet had been bound with wire. Their turbans were riddled with bullets that had been fired from point blank range.

At Lachhman Ridge, just below Patrol Base, 3/3 GR's Delta Company under command of 4 Sikh had withstood the sporadic shelling throughout 15 November. As soon as Patrol Base fell at 4.30 a.m., the Chinese